

Little Tsars

By Dominic Dominguez

(Anyusha) Anna Evgenevna Vronsky (27, dating Nikolai)

A caretaker. Wants to help, but doesn't know how. Who looks out for her?

(Matyusha) Matvey Evgenyevnich Vronsky (17, Anna's younger brother)

A fierce warrior of the revolution (in his mind). Chaotic and hypocritical. Wants to be special.

(Kolya) Nikolai Borisov Steklov (23, dating Anna, Sonja & Boris's son)

Brooding. Guilty for his own privilege. Has a child-like love for Anna.

Sonja Edvardovna Steklov (48, Nikolai's mother)

Direct and controlled. She believes she knows what everyone else is thinking.

(Borya) Boris Stanislavovich Steklov (53, Nikolai's father)

Comic relief. Happy to finally be someone of importance. He realizes little more than what's directly in front of him.

(Sasha) Alexander Dmitrievich Protopopov (65, Minister of the Interior)

A "yes-man". Just wants to relax. A little boy with grey hair in big man's shoes.

SCENE 1

(Matyusha) Matvey Evgenyevnich Vronsky (17, Anna's younger brother)

(Anyusha) Anna Evgenevna Vronsky (27)

Anna is sitting in front of her dresser in her room. Her cat sleeps on her dresser and she pets it gently. Anna is in a soft teal dress that she only takes out for very special occasions. Usually, those occasions are to celebrate other people and tonight is no different. She is applying lipstick and staring at herself in the mirror. After finishing her makeup, she smiles and looks at her reflection with affection. Then she leans forward and kisses herself, before sitting back to admire the lipstick stain puckering back at her.

ANNA

(Whispering) You're very pretty. Let's have a good night.

She further readies herself in some capacity (putting on earrings, blush, etc.) when Matvey enters the room, frantically searching for something, interrupting her tranquil pre-party ritual. The cat is awoken and jumps down from the dresser to move around the room and avoid the source of the noise.

ANNA

What are you looking for?

MATVEY

Have you seen my bag?

Matvey is crawling on the ground to reach under the couch, opening cabinets, etc.

ANNA

(Continuing to get ready) No.

MATVEY

Sorry, I just... I think I left it somewhere in here. Or it could be in my bedroom...

Matvey goes out of the living room, into his bedroom.

ANNA

Have you checked in the couch cushions?

MATVEY

Why would it be in the couch cushions?

Anna gets up and looks under the couch cushions. She finds his bag. She is about to tell him, but instead decides to search it- she thinks there might be drugs. And what does she find? She pulls out a small vial full of pale-yellow powder.

ANNA
Matvey, it's in here.

Matvey reenters.

MATVEY
Oh, thank god. I couldn't- *(he sees her holding the vial)*. Did you search my bag?

ANNA
What's this?

MATVEY
You can't do that, Anna! You're not my mom. That's my stuff!

ANNA
So, what is it? *(She inspects it closer)*.

MATVEY
If you're thinking it's drugs, I can tell you it's not drugs.

ANNA
Really? Mysterious vial of powder found in your bag isn't drugs? Matyusha, you're always lying to me. For years I've had to deal with your shit, and you think you'd have the basic bit of sense-

MATVEY
It's not drugs, I swear!

ANNA
Then what is it?

MATVEY
Sweetener.

ANNA
Sweetener?

MATVEY
For tea.

ANNA
Ok!

Anna goes into the kitchen and fills a glass with water. She walks back in the room and puts the glass on the table.

ANNA

I am going to pour this whole vial in my glass and drink it if you don't tell me the truth.

MATVEY

I-

ANNA

Ok.

She uncaps the vial.

MATVEY

Wait!

ANNA

What?

MATVEY

It's not drugs. Or drugs for pleasure at least. I swear... It's poison.

ANNA

Poison?

MATVEY

Yes.

ANNA

Why?

MATVEY

Oh. For rats.

ANNA

Oh, god Matyusha. Don't do this.

MATVEY

What? It's for rats. It is! I lay out a little bread- I was going to put it right outside where they gather and then they'll eat it and our rat problem will go away.

ANNA

What can I do little brother? I try to look after you. I try to give you a good life. I'm sorry. I guess it's not enough.

MATVEY

Don't be sorry! Nothing to be sorry about!

ANNA

I'll stay in tonight and we can talk about this. I just want you... you know I've only ever wanted you to be safe and happy. We can change things, things can always change if it's too much.

MATVEY

What the hell are you talking about Anna?

ANNA

The poison... I love you. I can't even say it. You're enough Matvey, I love you, you're enough.

MATVEY

No, no, it's not for me, it's for rats!

ANNA

Don't lie to me, please. If you can't even admit what it's for... I can't leave you alone. You'll have to stay somewhere safe, until you're ok again.

MATVEY

Anna, please it's not for me, it's for-

ANNA

Say rats one more time!

MATVEY

It's for the police!

ANNA

What?

MATVEY

The government, the secret police- the Okhrana, those fucking bastards out there killing us! I wanted to... I wanted to take care of the problem in our neighborhood. Help out our people, put an end to the terror.

ANNA

Matyusha, why?

MATVEY

What else is there to do? I can't- I can't live this way anymore! In fear, in constant fear of an attack! Attacks that will never be punished.

ANNA

Where did you get this?

MATVEY

There's a guy, who provides gear for the Socialist Revolutionaries. He's very reliable, but it cost me an arm.

ANNA

How were you... I don't understand.

MATVEY

It's really good stuff. *(He tries to take it back from Anna, but she refuses)*. At least put the cap back on then. Just a grain of that in your system, and within a day you're a goner.

ANNA

(Capping the vial and putting it into her dress) Matyusha... My boy. My little boy. What's driven you to such- to killing?

MATVEY

(Grabbing at his hair) How are you not? I fucking- our parents! They took them away- seven years ago and I've- where are they now? The Okhrana busted in here, unstoppable- I could do nothing. I was just a boy then, but now I'm a man! I've felt so guilty for so long because I did nothing, but I've reassured myself- said I was too young, but now that I'm 17, I'm an adult, I can do something! I can topple the whole damn thing!

ANNA

But this isn't it, Matvey. There are other ways.

MATVEY

Like what? Like "changing the world" with your rich boyfriend? Do you still really believe that?

ANNA

I don't know if we're going to change the world, but yes! Nikolai and I are doing things, they're small right now, but they'll evolve.

MATVEY

You're naive, Anna! You're living in a fantasy world sister. We're dying by the day, mowed down in the streets for looking too leftist.

ANNA

Nikolai has connections. We can influence people. There doesn't need to be violence- if we hurt people we're just as bad as them.

MATVEY

No, we're not. Because when the Okhrana broke in here, armed and in numbers to drag away our parents- innocent people, it was for no reason other than to preserve their power. It was to

scare us and cause us pain, stomp out any morsel of hope, so they could keep what they already have. If I kill them, it's to lift my people and stop those feral sadists.

ANNA

Matyusha, I think they're scared like us- like you're scared right now! And that's driving them to do bad things. And they're not aware of us, they don't know we're real people. But I think if I can talk to some powerful people, if I could get familiar with them and make them listen-

MATVEY

Why would *his* people ever do something to help *us*? Why do you think your voice would have any pull? You're an outsider.

ANNA

Because Nikolai can do something.

MATVEY

You're not Nikolai.

ANNA

We're getting married, Matyusha! I didn't tell you, and I hate telling you now, but I just can't deal with your anarchist bullshit.

MATVEY

Socialist.

ANNA

Whatever! I will have influence, and a handful of power. A little power with my ideals will go a long way.

MATVEY

You're being foolish, Anna. They'll never let one of us in. And if they let you in then you'll no longer be one of us. He's rich and rich people don't look out for poor people. It's not in their nature.

ANNA

You don't know him.

MATVEY

I don't know if you're just being foolish because you're lovestruck or if he's lying to you, but you're living in a fantasy.

ANNA

He's read Marx. He cried when he read Engel's essays about the factory workers in England. He wants to make a change.

MATVEY

There are millions of women and children dying in the streets, waiting for some rich man to walk by and throw them a crumb. But we can't wait anymore! We can't wait for you or Nikolai to "make a difference". We have to take it, by force. It's the only way.

ANNA

You're so angry Matyusha. There's so much violence in your words.

MATVEY

There's so much violence in the world.

Anna goes to Matyusha and takes his hand.

ANNA

Matyusha, I love you. I feel like there's deep pain in you and I wish I could help.

MATVEY

No, you don't.

ANNA

Yes, I do.

MATVEY

Don't pretend you care, because if you really cared you would fight for me.

ANNA

There isn't a need-

MATVEY

Anna, I- last week I was jumped.

ANNA

What?

MATVEY

The cops. I was... with a few friends from the SR's, handing out bread to children behind the schoolhouse, and they came on us, like a pack of dogs. I saw them and I tried to run but they- the look in their eyes. One grabbed my collar and turned me around to face him, and just the look- it was like the devil! He threw me down on the ground and dragged me by the neck. My pants came down and I was exposed, like a freak! In front of all of those kids... And they stared at me. I felt like I had let them down. And my butt was bloody from the stones on the ground, and he just threw me down and started kicking me. I covered my head and... he made me feel like nothing. Like a doll. A toy. An object. I never felt like I was worth so little. *(Starts crying)*

He spat on me.

ANNA

Oh Matyusha (*She starts to comfort him*).

MATVEY

(*Through tears*) It won't stop, Anna! They won't stop hurting people- they're hateful, born to be hateful! They're gonna kill me! I want them gone. GONE!

Suddenly a knock is heard. They both sit up.

NIKOLAI

(*Through the door*) Anna? Are you there? I'm sorry, I know I arrived late but we have to get going.

ANNA

(*Whispering*) Shit!

MATVEY

(*Whispering*) Is that him?

NIKOLAI

Hello? I think I hear you.

ANNA

Yes Niki! Coming!

MATVEY

Niki?

ANNA

Shut up. And stay here.

MATVEY

You're leaving?

ANNA

Yes! We'll talk more later. Can you just stay out of trouble, for a few hours while I'm gone?

MATVEY

Where are you going?

ANNA

Some function for Nikolai's father. He won some government award for some infrastructure project.

NIKOLAI

Anna, what are you saying? I'm sorry, I really don't want to make my mother wait. She's very anal about punctuality.

MATVEY

Anna, I'm distraught! Are you really going to leave me in this state?

ANNA

I'm sorry Matyusha. I love you. I'll be back soon, and I'll be thinking of you the whole time.

MATVEY

What will I do when you're gone?

ANNA

Read a book?

MATVEY

I've read all the good ones.

ANNA

Ok, Matyusha.

MATVEY

Just remember your people when you're there. I'll always be here for you.

ANNA

(Nearing the door) Thank you. Goodbye.

MATVEY

Ok, bye bye.

Anna leaves. Matvey putters around the room for a minute, waiting for the sound of footsteps and distant conversation to fade. He bolts the door and runs to his room. The cat hops onto the couch for a nice nap.

SCENE 2

(Anyusha) Anna Evgenevna Vronsky (27, dating Nikolai)
 (Kolya) Nikolai Borisov Steklov (23, dating Anna, Sonja & Boris's son)
 Sonja Edvardovna Steklov (48, Nikolai's mother)
 (Borya) Boris Stanislavovich Steklov (53, Nikolai's father)
 (Sasha) Alexander Dmitrievich Protopopov (65, Minister of the Interior)

Anna, Nikolai, Sonja, and Boris sit at a table with white tablecloth. In front of each of them sits a wine glass. Anna and Nikolai's are full, and Sonja is pouring Boris's unfinished glass into her own. Boris is not paying attention, too busy darting his head around trying to take in this safari of very important people.

ANNA

I really am very grateful for the invitation to dinner. I was looking forward to meeting you both, Nikolai has said-

BORIS

(Turning to his wife and ignoring Anna) Is that Alexander Dmitrievich Protopopov? Ah! I am going to scream. How do I look, do I look clean and professional? *(He adjusts his tie and makes his most powerful face).*

SONJA

You look very handsome dear.

BORIS

Ok, then I am going to go over and introduce myself. Wish me luck!

Boris gets up and leaves.

SONJA

Isn't your father adorable Kolya? He's so excited to finally be someone of importance.

NIKOLAI

He reeks of desperation.

SONJA

Nikolai Borisov! Do not speak that way of your father. Your education has made you spoiled.

NIKOLAI

No, merely aware.

SONJA

It is hard for you to understand what this all means to your father. You have so many prospects,
but when I was young-

NIKOLAI

Ah, this speech for the thousandth time.

ANNA

Why are you being so rude to your parents? They have done so much for you.

SONJA

I am just saying, your father used to think his best chance at a meaningful life was a meaningful death on the battlefield. Now he can support a family and leave behind a legacy. And he is respected.

NIKOLAI

You're right, I am happy that he is happy. I just do not think *I* could be as happy receiving accolades for thoughtlessly following orders. I fear having a job like this. He lays down telegraph wire-

SONJA

He is the project designer.

NIKOLAI

But there is no passion there! Where does he find meaning? Who is he doing it for?

SONJA

For his country.

NIKOLAI

And what is this country? Where am I? Who am I?

SONJA

Is this really the place to be so existential?

NIKOLAI

I have had many questions lately.

SONJA

And apparently no answers.

Beat.

(Turning to Anna) So Kolya tells me you are a nurse, but for dogs?

ANNA

Oh, well, all types of animals. I am a veterinarian.

SONJA

Hm, is that really necessary in this present moment?

ANNA

What do you mean?

SONJA

Oh just with so many people suffering, is it really worth it to focus on the cats and dogs right now?

NIKOLAI

Mama, what are you doing? Leave this poor girl alone.

SONJA

I am just asking questions.

ANNA

Well, they get sick, too. And it is hard to watch them suffer.

SONJA

Yes, but with only so many medical supplies, should we really waste them on a dog? I mean they don't live nearly as long, they bite, carry disease, and no matter how hard you try they will never speak good Russian.

NIKOLAI

Mother, now you are being harsh. Anna is a caring woman. And she's young-

SONJA

Older than you.

NIKOLAI

I just mean she did not plan out her life for war!

SONJA

You should always be prepared for war.

Boris enters flustered, practically bubbling at the mouth with "celebritis"- a syndrome caused by the overwhelming experience of meeting your idol.

BORIS

Sonja, my dear. Come with me! Protopopov said he wants to meet you. Protopopov! Wants to meet my wife! Come, come, come.

Boris pulls Sonja out of her seat and rushes her off to Protopopov's table.

NIKOLAI

(Suddenly more cheery) Well, this is fun. I am having fun, are you having fun?

ANNA

Niki, I think your mother hates me.

NIKOLAI

No, she just needs time to adjust.

ANNA

She's trying to scare me away.

NIKOLAI

Ah don't mind her, she's just protective! Her childhood was rough and traumatic- she spent her youth stealing bread and living under bridges. And don't worry too much about the dog stuff. She was attacked by a wild dog as a kid; it nearly tore her leg off. If she has enough wine, she'll probably show you her scar.

ANNA

(Beat) It didn't seem... I know that you're nervous- Have you told your mother that we're engaged?

NIKOLAI

I believe I may have mentioned it.

ANNA

What did she say?

NIKOLAI

Well, I more *primed* her for a conversation. But, I will tell her tonight!

ANNA

You want to do this, right?

NIKOLAI

Of course!

ANNA

Sometimes I feel like I say things that are serious, and you just treat them like a game.

NIKOLAI

What? You are the world to me. That hurts.

ANNA

I'm sorry. I just want to make sure you're as serious about me as I am about you.

NIKOLAI

When I wake up in the morning and hear the birds chirping, I swear they are singing your name.
Your touch is heaven. I love you.

ANNA

I love you too. *(Beat)* And would you try and talk nice about me when they're here?

NIKOLAI

I did!

ANNA

I know, I know. I'm sorry, I don't mean to criticize you. Your parents scare me and they think you're gold. Any kind word about me would mean a lot coming from you.

Nikolai takes her hand and looks her in the eye.

NIKOLAI

Why are you so worried? Just have fun! My father and the government are stupid, and this celebration of my father's promotion is a waste of time and money, but we might as well have fun while we're here.

He holds up his wine glass, but Anna stares at hers frigidly.

ANNA

I do not feel like drinking.

NIKOLAI

Why?

ANNA

Well, we said we were going to avoid consuming any superfluous food or drink - to be in solidarity with our starving brothers, and to not waste what others need.

Nikolai lowers his glass.

NIKOLAI

But the wine is already poured. It would be a waste not to drink it.

ANNA

I'm sorry, I don't want to scold you. You can drink it if you like.

NIKOLAI

(Pushing his glass away) But you will judge me if I do.

ANNA

I didn't think it was about me, I thought you wanted to do this.

NIKOLAI

I do! I just thought maybe tonight would be the exception.

ANNA

It can be.

NIKOLAI

(Raising his wine glass again) Will you drink with me?

ANNA

I meant for you; I really don't want to.

NIKOLAI

(Lowering his glass again) Then I won't either.

ANNA

Sorry.

NIKOLAI

No! Do not be sorry. You're right, this is what I want. Plus, there are other ways we can enjoy tonight.

Nikolai shifts towards her, placing his hand on her thigh. She reaches down and grabs his hand.

ANNA

Nikolai!

NIKOLAI

What?

ANNA

Here?

NIKOLAI

Just a taste.

ANNA

But, there are people everywhere. Your parents are right over there.

NIKOLAI

Ah, nobody will notice. C'mon.

ANNA

Wait, I don't think this is a good idea.

NIKOLAI

Hm, we can go to the bathroom then.

ANNA

Are you joking?

NIKOLAI

I don't know, I mean... we could be outside enjoying a cigarette, or... maybe (*Grabs the wine glass with his unoccupied hand and moves it slowly towards her dress*) you can spill wine on your dress and go to the bathroom to clean it off, and I can get up to refill your glass!

ANNA

(*Grabbing his wrist with her unoccupied hand*) No, Niki! I really don't want to do this here.

NIKOLAI

(*Nikolai draws back a little*) I'm sorry. I thought this could be an adventure. Sometimes we do things like this.

ANNA

We do, I'm just... this place makes me nervous.

Nikolai spots Sonja walking up and he rapidly moves both of his hands back to the table, spilling a little wine on the cloth.

SONJA

Nikolai, your father told me to come and get you. He says Protopopov needs to meet his strong, special, talented, intelligent, first-born son.

NIKOLAI

(*Looking at Anna, broodish again*) Mmm, what could be a greater pleasure.

Nikolai gets up and leaves Sonja and Anna alone. Sonja sits down and begins to sip her wine.

ANNA

So, was it nice to meet Protopopov?

SONJA

Hm?

ANNA

Protopopov, is he a nice man?

SONJA

Nice. Hm, he is the minister of the interior, who gives a shit if he is nice. (*Beat*) But yes, he is actually quite nice.

ANNA

Oh, that's interesting. I didn't think someone could be so powerful and also nice.

SONJA

Oh, at what position of power does someone stop being nice?

ANNA

I don't know, I just- when people are making decisions about things they'll never see or touch, I think it turns them cold.

SONJA

Hm. Well, Protopopov certainly hurts people.

ANNA

He does?

SONJA

Wow, it's easy to surprise you.

ANNA

Well, I thought you said he was nice.

SONJA

"Nice" people can hurt people. He points his finger at the horizon, and they build a railway to reach it, he draws a circle on a map and it becomes a new country, his wife scolds him in the morning and the Okhrana arrest 100 subversives. He is nice, but he's a fool, and whether you're a fool or a bastard, somebody is going to die when you're given power.

ANNA

Is he in charge of the... defense of the state against rebellion?

SONJA

He oversees the police and the Okhrana.

ANNA

Does he give them orders directly? Like if a revolutionary needed to be arrested, would he tell them who and how?

SONJA

You really are a little monkey, aren't you?

ANNA
Excuse me?

SONJA
This conversation is like talking to a toddler. I thought you were my son's elder, not his little child.

ANNA
(Beat.)
I do not know how to talk to you. I am trying to be pleasant.

SONJA
(Flippantly) Yes, it is apparent. Stop trying, you sound stupid.

ANNA
Well, what am I to say to you then?

SONJA
Nothing is fine.

ANNA
What did I do to you?

SONJA
Nothing tangible.

ANNA
(Muttering) And you say I'm frustrating.

SONJA
(Sonja looks Anna up and down.) You have a stain on your sleeve.

ANNA
(Looks at the stain on her sleeve) You treat me like trash because... a mark on my dress?

SONJA
The gold and silver in your jewelry clash, your blush is clumpy and obviously expired, and I saw your mouth watering at the phrase "bread for the table".

ANNA
I- well- I apologize if my manners are not perfect- I-
Sonja leans toward Anna and puts her finger on Anna's lip.

SONJA

Shhh, honey it's really much simpler than that. I can smell you're poor from a kilometer away, and I don't want you with my boy.

Anna grabs Sonja's hand and moves it down.

ANNA

Put your damned finger down or I may bite it off.

SONJA

Honestly, as mean as I'm being, there really is no criticism.

ANNA

Ha! I may smell like poverty, but you had your finger up in my face, and it reeks of...
(*judgmental bitch*). I really wish you wouldn't touch me like that.

SONJA

Have you ever eaten a cockroach for the calories?

ANNA

No-

SONJA

On the playground at school- did you let the other children break your fingers for a laugh, so you could earn a measly kopek?

ANNA

I feel you're building a point.

SONJA

I was poor, almost certainly poorer than you, but I know your type. And because of our shared experience, I have a window into your mind. I see that hunger in your eyes. I know your energy, I know what you dream about, and I know what you're willing to do to get it. You see my son, and being the sweet boy he is, and the attractive girl you are- he is like an open door to an easy life.

ANNA

You think I'm some kind of gold-digger? I love Nikolai-

SONJA

Like a dog loves his bowl! (*Laying it out for her*) He is food, he is warmth, he is security. To you, he is not a person, and he deserves better than that.

ANNA

I have done nothing. Nothing, for these accusations.

SONJA

And there's nothing you have to do. Just by your attitude, your desperation to please Boris and I, it's so obvious you need this. And even if you do like my boy, you can never be honest with him. You can never help him grow. Because behind every kiss, every touch of the hands, and pleasant "good morning" is "*I want your money*". You can never leave him, and for that reason you can never really love him, because you do not *choose* to be with him. Take it from me- Boris is a nice man, but he has the charm of a potato. We are just lucky to be pretty.

ANNA

(Beat.)

I have not been honest, because the moment I stepped in this room I felt fake. But to be honest, I hate your money. It makes me sick to my stomach. How dare you treat me this way... And you sip on your wine, and I just think of the tired farmers who- I hope you taste the dirty feet that smashed those grapes.

SONJA

I can taste the feet, and I love it.

ANNA

I do not want your money.

SONJA

Then why are you here?

ANNA

Nikolai. And Boris, too. I guess...

SONJA

Maybe you don't even know yet... But if you find yourself looking for security in this relationship, I will make sure being with my boy is a hardship. And if you go through hell to be with Nikolai, then maybe I will trust you.

(Beat. The next sentence is daggers.)

He's proud to be with someone like you. He thinks it makes him a *good person*.

A blissfully drunk Boris comes running up holding the hand of a flabbergasted Protopopov. Nikolai trails behind, embarrassed by his father's behavior.

BORIS

(Pointing at Anna) Look, look, I told you! Very pretty, my son- he has- a very pretty woman. If you want, I'm telling you, she's great- you can dance with her! *(He leans down to Sonja, and whispers very audibly)* It's Alexander Dmitrievich Protopopov! He's going to dance with Sonja!

SONJA

I am Sonja, her name is Anna.

BORIS

(Turning his attention to Anna) Anna! Dance with Protopopov! Have fun! It's my birthday!

PROTOPOV

(Charming and polite) Oh, really. She does not have to do anything she doesn't want to. *(To Anna)* I'm very sorry, he dragged me over here.

NIKOLAI

Dad, you are making a fool of yourself.

BORIS

(Swiveling on his feet to look his son in the eyes) When did you become sooooo boring? You bring your nice lady here for a night of excellence, and you're with me talking to Protopopov the whole night and then when you're doing that- PAH! You talk about economics! This girl *(gesturing to Anna)* THIS is a fine girl, and she deserves the best... *(Presenting)* Protopopov!

PROTOPOPOV

Really, I am sorry, and I think Nikolai should-

NIKOLAI

I hate dancing.

ANNA

Well then that settles it! I will dance with Protopopov *(She lends her hand to him, and he pulls her up, shocked by many of tonight's events. They exit together.)*

BORIS

(Wiping back his hair, turning to his wife, and extending his hand) Madame, may I lend you my hand?

SONJA

I really am not in the mood to dance right now.

BORIS

(Turning to Nikolai)

Bah! Your mother, she is just- she never took dancing lessons, never gained any confidence for an affair like this. But woo! When she was young? Poor girls- they dance like fire, *(shaking his head)* but they are not trained. And then they get old and PAH! -all they want to do is sit. *(Turning to Sonja and pinching her cheek)* They work too hard. *(Turning back to Nikolai and once again whispering very audibly)* Plus she has a weird foot thing. Get her a little more drink and she'll show you.

Boris bounces off, leaving Nikolai and Sonja sitting alone. Anna and Protopopov can be seen dancing together close by. Through this next conversation Anna is staring at Nikolai whenever

she can, and Nikolai steals glances towards her. They are both watching the other's behavior but avoid making eye contact.

SONJA
Are you having fun?

NIKOLAI
Splendid time.

SONJA
Did you enjoy meeting Protopopov?

NIKOLAI
I don't know, hard to get along with anyone complicit in murder.

SONJA
Kolya! When did you start talking like this? Lately with you, everything has been famine and murder. *(Pinching his cheek)* Remember when you liked horses?

NIKOLAI
Ah well, all the horses have been shipped off to war, so not much horse to love anymore, except if you like their meat.

SONJA
Nikolai. I am tired of this.

NIKOLAI
What?

SONJA
I don't know what happened to you.

NIKOLAI
I grew up mama.

SONJA
No. You are acting like a spoiled teenager.

NIKOLAI
Spoiled? You are the one who acts spoiled. All day you just sit home and drink wine. I am out there doing things!

SONJA
(Grabbing his shirt collar) You dare speak to your mother that way?

NIKOLAI

I'm sorry mama. That was rude of me to say.

(Sonja releases him)

I just mean... you're still young but you act old. You act like the world is over. You're my inspiration! I remember when I was a kid- you would take me to protests. In secret, remember? On the days we were alone. And now you scold me because I don't want to be a government stooge like my father.

SONJA

You should count yourself lucky to be a government stooge. Most men your age are dying in the trenches.

NIKOLAI

Well, maybe I don't want to be lucky.

SONJA

Well, too bad! You are lucky. And you should be ashamed of yourself for wasting that luck. Associating with... I don't know what drives you to keep seeing that girl.

NIKOLAI

Mama! You are too mean to her.

SONJA

No, Kolya. You are.

NIKOLAI

I respect her. She has taught me so much, about the world- about the daily struggle of the impoverished and unwanted. She is like a shining star in the darkness.

SONJA

To you she is like a zoo attraction.

NIKOLAI

That's horrible.

SONJA

It's true. You have this recent morbid fascination with the needy and the dying, and you see this girl- less fortunate than you, and out of curiosity you get with her. Maybe you are bored, maybe you are guilty, but to you she is a fantastic window to how the other half lives.

NIKOLAI

You say such ugly things mama. Is this what being rich does to you? Every day you spend in our big house makes you a little emptier.

SONJA

You don't like our money? Then you're cut off.

NIKOLAI

Mama!

SONJA

What? It is like cancer, yes? Well, then- I am a surgeon! The tumor is removed. You're welcome.

NIKOLAI

Gah! Well, good then! Living with nothing is a nobler way of life. (*Imagining his new life*) I'll sleep on the streets, look up at the stars. It'll do me good. I'll do manual labor and get big muscles.

SONJA

Kolya (*shaking her head*), you have the mind of a rich man. If you thought like a beggar, you would be on your knees pleading for me to change my mind. You have the heart of a rich man because you think you want to be poor- for the experience, for the perspective, so you can speak about it to your rich friends and say, "I know what *it* is". But you don't know *it*, because you have autonomy. *It* is the condition of being stuck and unable to change your fate. *That* makes someone truly poor. If you really knew what it was to be poor, you wouldn't choose to live a day that way.

NIKOLAI

I- You are a traitor to your own kind! How can you have lived that way and escaped, and not want to turn around and help those still stuck?

SONJA

Kolya. You have such a good heart. But you will do no good waiting in a bread line, making some poor bastard behind you wait another minute for his rations. You have opportunity, education- use it. Become a government stooge, and then work your way up. Make a difference.

NIKOLAI

It just feels so icky- (*Sonja hits him lightly upside the head*). Ow!

SONJA

You want to live like you're working class? Then try doing what you're told! The proletariat don't work in factories because they want to.

NIKOLAI

I just fear who I'll become.

SONJA

Instead fear who you are. Stop romanticizing the poor and help them! Cynics point out all the problems and do nothing to solve them. Accept that you're privileged and use it for good.

NIKOLAI

Maybe.

SONJA

Bah, maybe! (*Grabs his hair, pulls him in close, and kisses him on the forehead*). You are so funny sometimes. I see why all the girls like you.

NIKOLAI

Sometimes I wonder what Anna sees in me.

Boris runs back in. He looks panicked.

SONJA

Borya, sweetheart, what is it?

BORIS

(*Out of breath*) A camera.

SONJA

What?

BORIS

They have a camera. We can take a picture. But we must run. A line is forming.

NIKOLAI

I do not want to pose, the whole thing-

BORIS

(*Stoops down to his son and grabs his collar*). You are such a twat. We are a family. We need a photo. We have no photos.

NIKOLAI

(*Pushing his father away*) Ok, ok! God, your breath smells like vodka.

BORIS

That is only because I have been drinking vodka.

SONJA

My love, I am not in the right condition-

BORIS

Augh, *twats*! Every one of you! You would not dance... (*falling to his knees and pleading*). I never ask you for anything and now, I just want to see us together, forever. It is my birthday wish.

SONJA

(Raising Boris from the ground) It is not your birthday, but I do love it when you beg. *(Turning to Nikolai)* Nikolai Borisov, we are going to take a picture.

NIKOLAI

(Sighs) Should I ask Anna to come?

BORIS

Is she family?

NIKOLAI

I guess not...

BORIS

Then don't bother! Let's go! *(Stares at his son discerningly)* Hm, but first adjust your tie and tidy yourself. I will save us a place in line.

Boris walks off with Sonja in tow and Nikolai begrudgingly stays behind to make himself look presentable. Anna walks back.

ANNA

Oh, where are you going?

NIKOLAI

Somewhere stupid. How was dancing with Protopopov?

ANNA

Fine, but I would have rather been dancing with you.

NIKOLAI

Mmm, yes, I'm sure.

ANNA

Are you jealous?

NIKOLAI

He is an ugly old man, of course not.

ANNA

Did you tell your mother that we're engaged?

NIKOLAI

No, not yet.

ANNA

Will you?

NIKOLAI
I don't know.

ANNA
You don't know?

NIKOLAI
I'm not sure it's worth it- getting the family involved.

ANNA
I... You don't want to marry me.

NIKOLAI
I don't know. Maybe it's not worth the conflict.

ANNA
I thought you would fight for me.

NIKOLAI
I don't understand. Why does there have to be fighting? Maybe it's ok if... I love you separately.

ANNA
What?

NIKOLAI
Sorry, I don't know, I have to go take a family photo.

Nikolai runs off leaving Anna stunned. Protopopov then walks up smiling, but his expression changes to concern when he sees the sorrowful look on Anna's face. He turns towards the direction Nikolai left.

PROTOPOPOV
Oh, I'm sorry, am I interrupting something?

ANNA
No. *(Recentering herself)* Before I walked away, you were telling me some anecdote about chicken.

PROTOPOPOV
Oh, yes. But it's really not important.

ANNA
No, no, I'm sorry I walked away and got distracted. I want to hear the end.

PROTOPOPOV

Ok, then take a seat and let's talk.

He pulls out her chair, waits for her to take a seat, and then takes his own.

PROTOPOPOV

So I ate the Tsarian's chicken and it was... *very dry*, but I would never admit it! But Trepov was just blabbering away about it, so I said, "you didn't like the chicken, then why don't you tell the Tsarina yourself." Alexandra was standing behind us and I called her over.

ANNA

Did you tell her?

PROTOPOPOV

No, no. I probably would have been shot! But it was too rich a moment, I couldn't help myself. He had to excuse himself to get a new change of pants. He was so scared.

ANNA

Mr. Protopopov, you are funny.

PROTOPOPOV

Please, call me Sasha.

ANNA

Ok, Sasha. *(Beat)* You know, I wouldn't have thought the Minister of the Interior would be such a good dancer.

PROTOPOPOV

Oh, and why not?

ANNA

The government - all of *you*. You always wear such serious faces, always conducting important business. I thought that would make you all stiff, not leave much room for dancing.

PROTOPOPOV

Ah, well you know, before I was one of *them*, I was just a man. And before that, I was a boy. And as a boy- *(with an eyebrow raised)* well as a boy... I had fun.

ANNA

Oh, yeah? What kind of fun.

PROTOPOPOV

Well, when I was young and dumb, and I thought the world was my playground, I would go out with my friends, and we would spend the whole night getting violently drunk and writing poetry.

ANNA
Poetry?

PROTOPOPOV
Oh, yes. And sometimes, the poems were quite... frisky.

ANNA
Would you share any?

PROTOPOPOV
Are you sure you can handle it?

ANNA
Yes, I am sure.

PROTOPOPOV
Mmmm, ok. But tell no one. Ah, let me think. Ok, here is one:

I was dating a girl from home,
With assets bigger than Rome,
I told her how pretty,
Were her giant titties,
And now I am sleeping alone.

ANNA
Wow.

PROTOPOPOV
Want to hear another?

ANNA
I am not so sure.

PROTOPOPOV
My girl is from Dnepropetrovsk (*Nee-prope-eh-trofsk*),
She is soft and she never talks,
Her hole smells like feet,
But it feels so neat!
It's true, I am fucking my sock.

ANNA
Those were... different than I was expecting.

PROTOPOPOV

See, I have fun. I am naughty. I can be a rebel.

ANNA

Yes, if only the rebels knew.

PROTOPOPOV

Then maybe they would think "his shoulders are a good spot for his head" and put away the guillotine.

ANNA

Yes... being hunted. That must be stressful.

A waiter comes over and hands Protopopov a drink. It is a bright color and ornamented with fruit.

PROTOPOPOV

This job has its ups and downs. On one hand, millions of people want me dead. On the other hand, I get delicious fruity drinks. *(He raises his glass and takes a sip. Anna eyes the glass wearily).*

ANNA

Do you ever write any beautiful poems?

PROTOPOPOV

Hm... once. But I am quite embarrassed to share it.

ANNA

Please?

PROTOPOPOV

Ahhhhh... ok. It is hard to refuse the request of a pretty woman:

My hands are dirty and my ball is round,
And I can kick it so far if I try.
I could chase it around the world twice,
And punch a big hole in the sky.

That funny cloud looks like a bear,
And the big one reminds me of dad.
I took my ball to play with him,
But he was too busy for that.

I think I'll fly a plane someday,
Like a bird high off the ground,
I'll visit a place that no one knows,

And maybe I'll never be found.

I can sit atop the largest rock,
And feel like the Tsar of the Earth,
On my island all alone,
With no one to tell me my worth.

ANNA

(Anna smiles and claps gently) That was... there's so much softness in you. How do you do it?

PROTOPOPOV

Do what?

ANNA

Wield so much power. I feel like, in my whole life... You start as a baby, right? Then you're a child, and that all takes somewhere between 14-25 years. And well, that's a quarter of your life already! How do you go from nothing, from drooling and wetting your diaper, to Ruler of the World, all in one lifetime? How do you gain the confidence to make such big decisions? I feel like I never stopped being a child.

PROTOPOPOV

Me too! Can you believe it? A child is in charge of our country. *(Looking around the room and placating to any loyalist eavesdroppers: 50% joking and 50% serious)* Not talking about the Tsar of course, just my humble self.

ANNA

But you can't feel that way! You negotiate wars. People are locked up on your orders.

PROTOPOPOV

I feel like my whole life I just said "yes". I just did what I needed to do to keep going. At one point it was studying for my math test, then it was filing papers, and then it was accepting this position. I don't know how I got here, it all happened in the blink of an eye.

ANNA

But as a child you had to do what you were told. I mean now you can... now *you could change things*.

PROTOPOPOV

What do you mean? What things?

ANNA

I'm sorry, I don't mean to imply anything. I just... I see the world and the people dying, our brothers dying, and I feel like if anyone could help it's you.

PROTOPOPOV

How? "How" I ask? You think I have power- ha! I have had this job for only a few months. If I act in a way that is not in accordance with the status quo- *BAM (snaps or claps), (whispers) I'm gone*. I'm just a pencil-pusher with a fancy title, there's always someone above you. And even the one above me, as powerful and wise as he is, what can he do? He says, "end the war", we stop fighting, and Opa! "Hello Germans." Once the fighting starts it cannot end until one side has been squashed. No one really makes decisions in this world, except God.

ANNA

But have you tried-

PROTOPOPOV

Of course I've tried! I try... I... I'm a coward Anna. But even if I wasn't, we all do what we have to do- to survive, to take care of ourselves. And if someone else needs the opposite of what you need, well that's the basis of all conflict.

ANNA

I hope I never become so nihilistic.

PROTOPOPOV

Being so close to absolute power, it's like flying up to the sky and getting face to face with a star, and then you realize it's just painted on. It's made of the same stuff as what's down here on Earth. These "important people" are just angry men making decisions and not ever knowing the consequences.

ANNA

(Beat)

You seem tired.

PROTOPOPOV

I'll be tired until the SR's blow me up.

ANNA

Warring with your own people seems pointless. Maybe if you showed a bit more mercy-

PROTOPOPOV

(*Getting a little worked up*) Why? They would not show mercy to me. If those leftist rebels were with me now, they'd drag me away, twist off my toenails and hang me by my tongue. For people like me, they are very dangerous. If wild wolves roamed the streets, no one would blame us for locking them up. At least when we take people away, we are civil about it. These monsters are capable of horrors you couldn't imagine. Just last week we caught a few socialists selling drugs to children.

ANNA

I find it hard to believe there's nothing any of you can do.

PROTOPOPOV

Everyone is just doing what they need to survive. I don't blame the Germans when they shoot at us, because we're shooting at them. Nothing will change until we all die and people with different needs take power.

(Beat)

Anna, talking with you has made me realize all the stress I've been under.

(Beat)

I wish I was on a boat.

ANNA

(A second to think)

Can I help you relax?

PROTOPOPOV

Ok.

ANNA

Here, hold my hand. *(She reaches out her hand and takes his. He lets her.)* Close your eyes. *(He closes his eyes)* You're laying down on a raft floating on calm waters. The sun is resting gently on your closed eyelids and the gentle waves tickle your ears. *(She uses her other hand to take out the vial of poison from her dress.)* You feel the age of your body, but all that tension releases as mother Earth cradles you in her arms. *(She uncaps the poison and pours it into his drink.)* Relax and let her do the work. Let go of your worries and take the weight off your shoulders. *(She puts the vial away back in her dress.)* Have a good time tonight and be free for an hour.

Remember what it means to be human. Now open your eyes.

Protopopov opens his eyes. He smiles and they stare into each other's eyes for a moment. They release their hands.

PROTOPOPOV

You know, when I am this close to your face, the stars regain their spectacle for another moment.

ANNA

Sasha...

PROTOPOPOV

No, no. I'm sorry I don't mean to be inappropriate. You are just a very beautiful woman.

ANNA

Thank you.

PROTOPOPOV

(Raising his glass) Will you toast with me?

ANNA

Sure. *(She grabs her wine glass and raises it.)*

PROTOPOPOV

"To a night away from the chaos."

Protopopov and Anna clink glasses. He takes a sip first and then she follows. At that moment Boris walks up scolding Nikolai with Sonja trailing behind.

BORIS

Why can't you smile for one picture? *(Pointing to the sides of his mouth)* Are those muscles broken?

NIKOLAI

(Spotting Anna drinking her wine) Why are you drinking wine? I thought-

BORIS

Because they are in love son! Real love! *(He goes over and puts his arm around Anna and Protopopov).*

NIKOLAI

Pop, that's my girlfriend. They are not in love!

PROTOPOPOV

(Awkward) I should probably head back to my table.

BORIS

Nonsense! *(Spotting his drink)* What is that? It looks delicious. Do you mind if I... *(and without waiting for a response he grabs Protopopov's drink and takes a solid swig)* Most Holy Governing Synod... that's amazing! What kind of fruit is in this?

PROTOPOPOV

Well, I don't know, they just handed it to me.

BORIS

(Handing the drink to Nikolai) Kolya, try this! You'll love it, it's sour, like you!

Nikolai takes the drink.

ANNA

Wait!

NIKOLAI

What?

ANNA
Don't drink that...

NIKOLAI
Why?

ANNA
It is too sweet for you...

NIKOLAI
I'm tired of this political guilt, Anna. If you can drink wine, then I can try this cocktail. I mean, look at its color. When will I get to try something like this again?

Nikolai waits a moment for affirmation, but gets none, however Anna cannot think of another excuse- except for the poison of course. He takes a sip.

NIKOLAI
Oh yeah, it's pretty good Papa.

BORIS
Then it's official! Everyone at this party needs to try this drink. Sonja?

SONJA
Borya, sweetheart. You cannot hand out someone else's drink without their permission.

BORIS
Protopopov does not mind.

PROTOPOPOV
(Sarcastically) Yes, I only really wanted two sips.

BORIS
Fantastic! Sonja, try it.

SONJA
No, I think it will upset my stomach.

BORIS
The one good thing about growing up poor is the lack of sugar. Now, as an adult, you don't have a tongue for it. *(Pointing all around)* But I know these rich bastards do!

Boris runs off with the drink in hand. He can be heard off stage yelling things like "You've got to try it!"

PROTOPOPOV

That's my cue. *(He gets up to leave)* It was very nice to meet you all. Goodbye Anna.

Protopopov leaves.

ANNA

I... I think I should get going as well.

NIKOLAI

Anna don't be like this.

ANNA

Like what?

NIKOLAI

I don't get it. I saw you drink the wine. How can you get mad at me because I had one sip of a cocktail? I've been good, Anna.

Anna stands and kisses him on the cheek.

ANNA

(Trying not to cry) I'm not mad at you. I've never been mad at you, not for a second. I love you Niki.

NIKOLAI

(Hugging her) Then why are you leaving?

ANNA

I just... can't be here any longer.

NIKOLAI

Don't worry about them, just be with me! *(He pulls her in closer.)*

ANNA

No, Niki, I'm sorry. I have to leave. *(She pushes herself away).*

NIKOLAI

I talked with my mother.

ANNA

What?

NIKOLAI

I told her how much I love you, and she isn't pleased with our marriage, but I think we can make it work. We will make it work.

ANNA

Thank you. I... *(She grabs her coat without looking at him)* You want to be with me?

NIKOLAI

I love you, Anna. No matter what my parents say, I love you.

ANNA

I love you too. To the moon and back.

She gives him one more hug and runs out without acknowledging Sonja, who has been standing silently behind them.

NIKOLAI

I don't understand.

SONJA

Girls like that, they're hard to read.

NIKOLAI

I don't think she wanted to be here.

SONJA

I think she wanted to be with you.

NIKOLAI

Then why didn't she stay for dessert?

Sonja takes him in for a hug and kisses his forehead.

SCENE 3

Matvey (17)

Anna (27)

Matvey is laying on the couch, asleep. We hear the sound of keys fumbling in the door and mild cursing; Matvey does not stir. Anna opens the door and enters her house in a daze. Robotically she fixes the latch and then turns to stare at her living room. She sees Matvey asleep on the couch and heads to him hesitantly. She is relieved to find there is family in her home- she is not alone.

ANNA

(Approaching slowly) Matyusha?

He does not wake.

ANNA

(Now more rapid) Matyusha? Matyusha?

He is still. She runs to him in a panic and grabs his face.

ANNA

Matyusha, please no Matyusha, not you too, not you too...

MATVEY

(With eyes unopened, in a drunken stupor) Whaa, what?

Anna drops his head and stands up.

ANNA

Matvey. Are you ok?

MATVEY

I- am. I'm fine, I just want to...

ANNA

What?

MATVEY

Sleep.

Anna steps away and stares at him unbelieving. She paces for a moment, thinking what to do and then goes to him violently, slapping him repeatedly on the shoulder.

ANNA

(With violent desperation) Wake up! How dare you- I asked one thing of you,

ANNA
and you're here- asleep! Drugged up and
asleep! You're fucking high and I'm-
withering, I'm gone, and you're-

MATVEY
*(Waking up much more slowly than one
would expect)*
Hey... Hey - Hey! I am - I am- I'm here!

MATVEY
What do you want from me!

ANNA
You're fucking high, you fucking idiot you're high!

MATVEY
No I'm not, I'm not, I just fell asleep, Anna, please c'mon!

ANNA
Do you know what- I'm alone...

MATVEY
No, you're not alone. I'm here.

ANNA
You're not really here.

MATVEY
We're family. *(Starting to go back to sleep)* You love... me...

ANNA
Stop it! It's not good, I'm bad, I'm bad, I'm bad... *(breaks down crying)*

MATVEY
(Realizes something is very wrong. Leans up to touch her) Hey, hey-

ANNA
Don't touch me! I can't believe you. Why do you even live? You try so hard to go away... do you
even want to be here?

MATVEY
Anna, yes, yes, I want to live.

Silence. Anna starts to shake and stands with her arms straight and stiff.

ANNA

I don't believe you. I want to be alone.

She retreats to her bedroom. Matvey sits up, blinking slowly and rubbing his eyes. He stretches his arms wide, yawning big, and cracks his neck from side to side. He starts to move to fall asleep again, but stops, and shimmies his butt around. He lifts up his hip, looks below him, screams and scrapes himself to the floor. Laying there, mangled and flattened, is Anna's cat.

ANNA

(Hearing the scream and from the other room) What?

MATVEY

Oh god... (He leans toward the cat and pokes it. No movement)

ANNA

(Entering from her bedroom) What, what is it?

MATVEY

Anna, I didn't mean-

ANNA

Didn't mean what, what- (Spots her cat)

MATVEY

Anna. It was an accident.

Anna moves methodically to the couch and sits beside her cat. She pulls it gently into her lap and cradles her head down low. She pets it as slow and lovingly as one can touch another creature.

MATVEY

Anna, I'm sorry... I didn't mean.

ANNA

Matyusha, please.

MATVEY

I'm sorry Anna, just say you forgive me, I'm sorry.

ANNA

Matyusha, I'm begging you with all my being-

MATVEY

Anna, I swear it was an accident-

ANNA

SHUT UP! PLEASE! *(beat)* Leave me be...

MATVEY

I'll get you a new one... *(Stands up and retreats)* Anna, I love you.

Anna doesn't acknowledge him. She just stares down at the innocent little prince in her arms. What did it do? Nothing. It did nothing to deserve this. It didn't even know death. It didn't know its context. It just existed and purred and loved me. I'm sorry. I'm sorry my love.

ANNA

I wish I had died right there, in his arms. I wish I had eaten cake with him, and drank wine with him, and let him love me. I wish we lived in a small house somewhere far away and he would kiss me in the morning. I wish you were there, too, and I'd feed you little treats. I wish there was silence. I wish I was dead and I wish there was peace.

Curtains close.